



Linux On The Go

This article documents some of the things that you'd generally do if you wanted to build that perfect Linux laptop. After all, you paid for a laptop, and you want Linux—so you should get it!

Well, it took some time, but I'm finally the owner of a laptop. It's a Dell Vostro 1088n, with a 2.2 GHz Intel Core 2 Duo processor with hardware virtualisation assists; 4 GB of DDR2-800 RAM, a 320 GB hard drive, and a dedicated 512 MB ATI Mobility Radeon HD4330 GPU. It came pre-installed with Ubuntu 8.10, and cost a mere Rs 38,000. Cool deal for a Linux laptop, you say—but is it?

From my experience, I've come to know that even the so-called 'Linux Laptop' isn't perfectly Linux-compatible. The first thing I did when I received the laptop was wipe

the hard disk clean, including all the Dell Recovery stuff, and install Ubuntu 10.04 Lucid Lynx from a daily build. And I ran into a barrage of problems.

The likely problems

Let me cover the problems that you're likely to face (i.e., what I faced on my laptop):

- Dell's tinkered with the ACPI of the BIOS, and somehow made it non-standard. Linux installed and ran fine, but the machine wouldn't automatically power off on shutdown. At the end of the shut-down process, I'd need to press the power button to turn